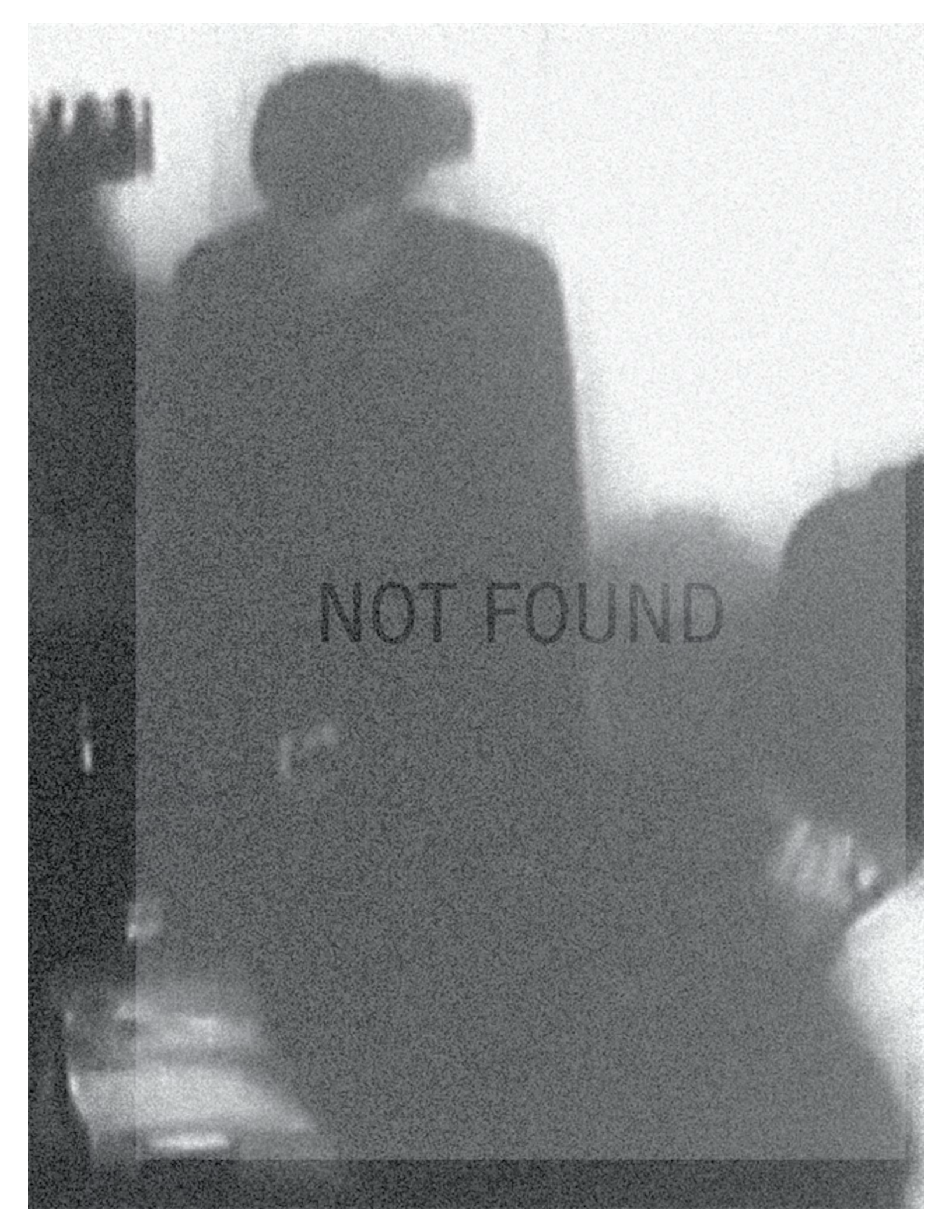




NOT FOUND



ELEPHANT IN THE ROOM

PRELUDE

“Elephant in the Room” is a series of eco-fables for the climate crisis. Calls to climate action have expanded accountability to institutions that were established during the nascent stages of industrial capitalism and through its extractivist wealth. Such motions are an invitation to reckon with and interrogate their own entanglements with carbon modernity, and to ultimate curate—if such a position is possible—new forms of action, within and beyond their walls. In the “Elephant in the Room” series, each eco-fable animates one fabulous figure from a natural history museum, so that the remains of such a specimen—skeleton, taxidermy, or composite mount—are brought back to life to recount their brutal environmental histories of dispossession and violence. They also implore, in their afterlives, responsibility from cultural institutions in the climate crisis. Each video is a 6-minute animation composed of rhyming verse, saturated color drawings, and occasional humor to stomach the tensions and tragedies of such narratives. The significance of figures—charismatic media figures and figures of speech—allows us to utter the unfathomable destruction of worlds; figuration bestows personhood upon the specimen and thus becomes a crucial aesthetic method. Figures are such material-semiotic knots, as they help us grapple inside the flesh of the world and make entanglements in which diverse clusters of meaning (narratives, discourses, precedents, imaginaries) shape one another through “creating performative images that can be inhabited.”¹ Akin to a death mask, the fable takes on the likeness of environmental folklore, aspiring to other forms of attention, and, dare we say, care. Such fabulations are not a break from environmental histories or futures, but a narrative tool that gives form to the present reality to delight and disturb you into other ways of thinking and feeling the Earth.²

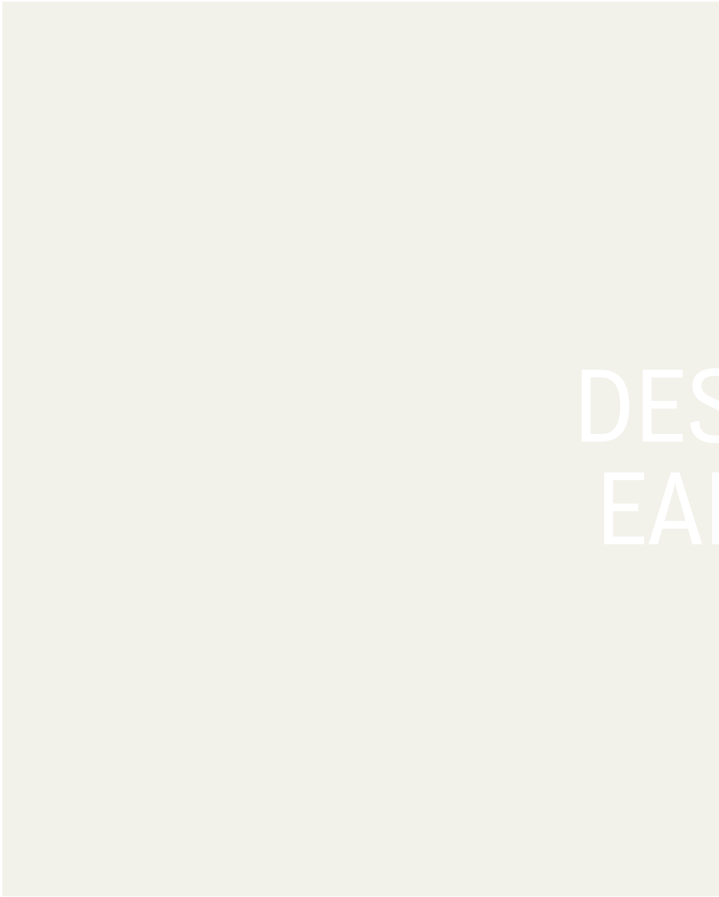
¹ “Elephant in the Room and Other Fables” has been funded by grants from MIT Humanities, Arts, and Social Sciences and the Graham Foundation for Advanced Studies.



AND OTHER FABLES

ELEPHANT IN THE ROOM

The series was initiated in the context of the international design competition Reimagining Museums for Climate Action, which asked how “museums could help society make the deep, transformative changes needed to achieve a net-zero or zero-carbon world.”³ Eponymously titled *Elephant in the Room*, the first fable in the series addresses the elephant in the room—the climate emergency—by telling the story of an elephant who charges out of the American Museum of Natural History to fight for environmental justice.⁴ The American Museum of Natural History in New York City is home to the famous taxidermy dioramas in the Akeley Hall of African Mammals. The iconic centerpiece, christened “The Alarm” by the renowned taxidermist Carl Akeley, is a herd of eight nervous elephants captured in a moment of great tension before a stampede. At least one of these elephants was shot by President Theodore Roosevelt during the Smithsonian-Roosevelt African Expedition (1909–1910), in which thousands of animals were “collected” to become property of the museum. Through these killings for science and conservation, the museum preached the gospel of racism and colonialism, outlined by Donna Haraway as the “Teddy Bear Patriarchy.”⁵ In her environmentalist rebellion, the herd’s African matriarch comes to life, charging out of the American Museum of Natural History to stomach the systemic legacies that dictate how some people and species may live while others must die. By taking her demands to the streets, the elephant underlines the role of museums in wider calls for climate justice, which necessarily involve a critical revision of their own legacies. In this sense, the elephant as a museum is less “curator”—one who stills or steals life in order to accumulate or organize a collection of things—and more “caretaker,” or one who tends to forms of life. “Elephant in the Room” was narrated by Donna Haraway and first exhibited at the Glasgow Science Center, coinciding with the 26th UN Climate Change Conference (COP) session in 2021. The need to craft such a praxis of care and response, or *response-ability*, in the words of Haraway, implies both a design to learn about an issue and an ethical obligation to become concerned and act.



DESIGN EARTH

WHALE SONG

The skeleton of Hope the blue whale was installed in the main hall of the Natural History Museum in London in 2017. In 1891, a young female blue whale was stranded on a sandbar while migrating off the coast of Ireland, where it was harpooned and auctioned off. Her body was butchered, her blubber boiled down, and her 4.5-tonne skeleton sold for £250 to the Natural History Museum. For almost 130 years, the whale was displayed in the museum’s Mammals gallery, and then repositioned to take center stage in the main hall in 2017. The whale has since been named Hope, a name chosen as a symbol of “humanity’s power to shape a sustainable future.” The decision to give pride of place to a whale was justified on conservationist grounds; as the museum director explained: “The very resources on which modern society relies are under threat. Species and ecosystems are being destroyed faster than we can describe them or even understand their significance. The blue whale serves as a poignant reminder that while abundance is no guarantee of survival, through our choices we can make a real difference. There is hope.”⁶ In 2019, 100 people simultaneously laid down underneath the blue whale skeleton for a half-hour Extinction Rebellion “die-in” protest. In the fable, Hope charges out of the Main Hall to swallow the legacies of the “Wonders of Industry,” which include both the material legacies of whaling—the first oil of the Industrial Revolution—and the cultural inheritances of Albertopolis, the nickname given to the area centered on Exhibition Road. Rooted in the 1851 Crystal Palace Exhibition, this thoroughfare houses various institutions, including the Natural History Museum, Royal Albert Hall, and the Victoria and Albert Museum, where the animation was first screened at the 2022 London Design Festival.

THE WAY OF THE DINOSAURS

On a Sunday morning in 1898, Andrew Carnegie, an industrialist–philanthropist who had led the expansion of the American steel industry in the late 19th century, read about a paleontological find. The *New York Journal* carried a full-page spread under the banner headline, “Most Colossal Animal Ever on Earth Just Found Out West!”, with an illustration of a long-necked dinosaur rearing up on its hind legs and peeking into an 11th-story window of the New York Life Building. Carnegie immediately wanted such a dinosaur for his namesake museum in Pittsburgh; he mailed the story with a check for \$10,000 to the museum’s director with the note: “Buy this for Pittsburgh.” In 1907, to house the monumental specimen, the Carnegie Museum expanded to add a new dinosaur hall, along with a foyer for the Music Hall, the Hall of Architecture, and the Hall of Sculpture. In the dinosaur hall, fragmentary geological remains are figured (with the support of a steel structure for the heavy bones!) to hold real consequences on what counts as Nature. Weaving the histories and futures of fossils and fossil fuel extraction, the fable cautions that fracking and the continued destruction of fossil fuels may bring humans to become extinct, in the way of the dinosaur. Set within the Hall of Architecture, the animation debuted at the Carnegie Museum of Art, convening around the exhibition “Unsettling Matter, Gaining Ground” in October 2023.

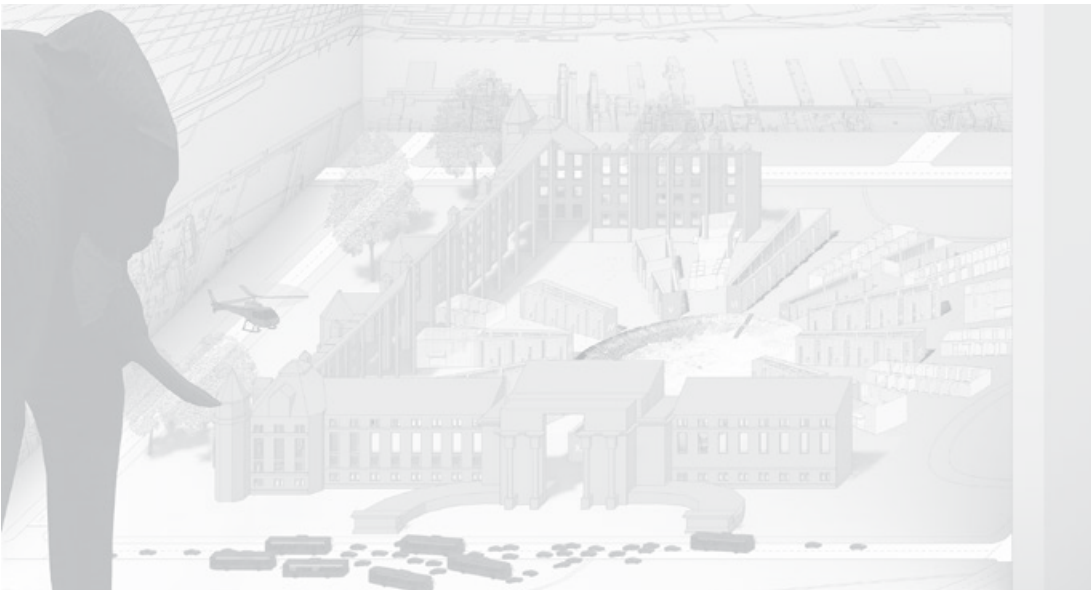
1	Donna Haraway, <i>Modest_Witness@Second_Millennium.FemaleMan@Meets_OncoMouseTM: Feminism and Technoscience</i> (London: Routledge, 1997).	5	<i>tural Education</i> 75:2 (2021), 264–274. See also animation at: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=i2Xz9fJ85IO
2	Isabelle Stengers, “The Cosmopolitical Proposal,” <i>Making Things Public: Atmospheres of Democracy</i> , ed. Bruno Latour and Peter Weibel (Cambridge, Mass.: MIT Press, 2005).		DESIGN EARTH Project Team: Rania Ghosn, El Hadi Jazairy, Monica Hutton, Anhong Li. Donna Haraway, “Teddy Bear Patriarchy: Taxidermy in the Garden of Evil,” <i>Social Text</i> No. 11 (Winter, 1984–1985), 20–64.
3	Reimagining Museums for Climate Action, https://www.museumsforclimateaction.org	6	Maev Kennedy, “Dippy the Diplodocus is displaced from Natural History Museum by blue whale.” <i>The Guardian</i> 29 January 2015, 22–23 .
4	Rania Ghosn & El Hadi Jazairy, “Elephant in the Room,” <i>Journal of Architec-</i>		

ELEPHANT IN THE ROOM

A visitor to the museum notices small things,
caught up in their own interests and the bias this brings.
What does this allow to go unaddressed?
The “elephant in the room,” as you may have guessed.

There is no bigger problem often ignored,
than the climate change we are marching toward.
Familiar with the feeling of being dismissed,
the elephant trumpets: a crisis does exist!

She lets out an alarm call to signal the herd,
to stampede into the streets, out from where they were stirred.
She broke out of the Museum of Natural History,
to protest human behaviour in all its misery.

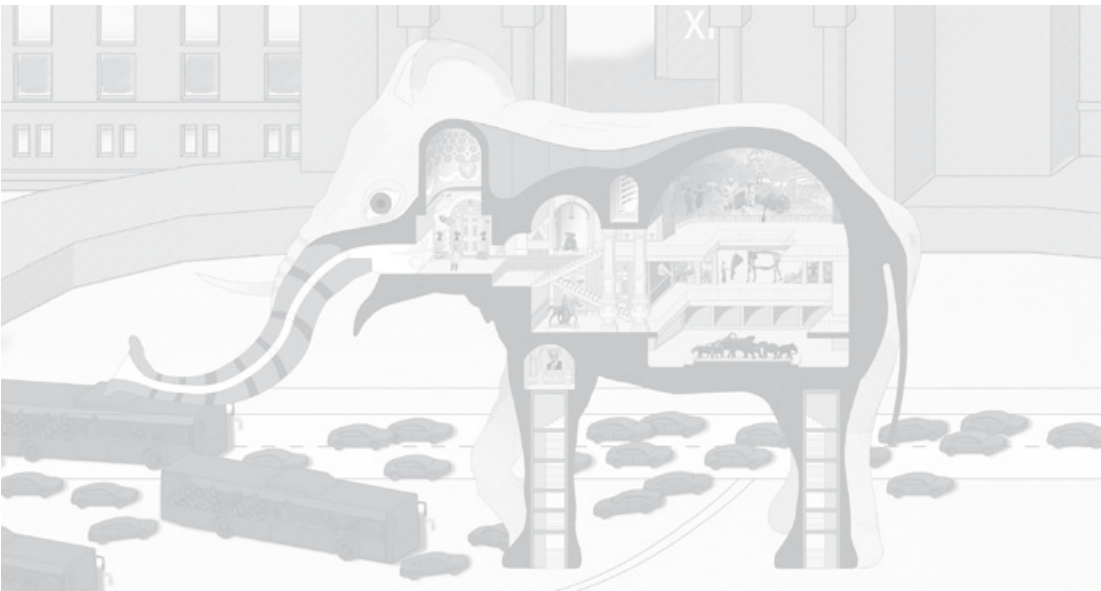
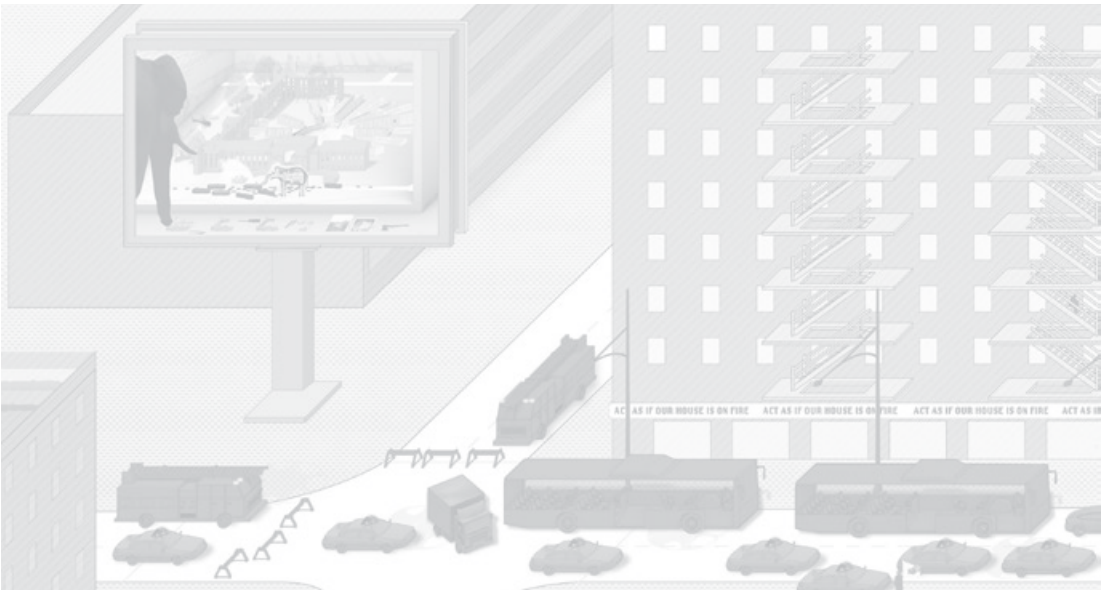


Thick in the air, and all over the day,
is a butane, propane, black carbon bouquet.
Climate issues have become more robust,
as diesel, paraffin and petrol combust.

The African elephant stomps down the street.
She is not detainable and not discreet;
She occupies Wall Street and protests in Times Square,
while sirens serenade and flies buzz in the air.

She raises her trunk to sound a deafening drum,
“Enough is enough! Surely you aren’t all just dumb.”
This matriarch elephant and seven more died,
Just so the museum could become more alive.

The Hall of African Mammals is where they were taken,
Waiting over a century for a time to awaken.
“The Alarm” is the centerpiece where their bodies were staged,
Frozen in a nightmare as if they were caged.



Around the room, other captive subjects stand by within dioramas that are stacked two tiers high. The Rhinoceros, Gorilla, Ostrich, and Lion silently protest in a perpetual die-in.

The elephant never forgets the source of its scar. “Speak softly and carry a big stick; you will go far.” A celebrated “conservationist” with a liking for hunting, is the American president the Elephant was confronting.

“The Big Stick” is the rifle President Roosevelt had in hand, as he stalked the Elephant’s footprints across open land. His son Kermit joined in on the Africa expedition, and shot her small calf taking after the politician.

The Elephant twitches to life in the Africa Hall. As if no time has passed, she remembers it all. Her reddish-brown eyes with German glass in their place, open to look museumgoers in the face.

She devours a book that a companion had written, on structures of power and knowledge she did not fit in. The “Teddy Bear Patriarchy” is a violent tale, of capitalism, supremacy, and the white human male.

With eyes no longer blind she sees what her body can make, the world on her mind that no one can take. She looks around the room and says “The one thing I know, is that the teddy bear patriarchy will have to go!”

The creature denounces the stuffed Teddy and its monsters. She has had quite enough of environmental imposters; the equestrian statue, the plaque honoring David Koch, were swallowed using her trunk shortly after she woke.

The mammal’s belly rumbles with resonant demands: to decolonize, divest, and dismantle, she firmly stands. Like a calving iceberg, earthquake, or volcanic eruption, her trumpeting call thunders a long-distance disruption.

Her revival starts an autopsy fit for the ages, where tools are used to dissect the museum in stages. Natural History becomes an building taxidermy, in a plan to make the most avid climate deniers squirmy.



Only the museum’s facade remains in place, to repair the damage to the very last trace. It frames a graveyard where the Elephant can finally rest, with the enormous weight she has lifted right off of her chest.

In the garden of a damaged planet no collection is held, Only the demand for action—that’s why the Elephant rebelled! A Climate Countdown Clock will keep time and enforce The twelve years that remain for us to change course.

Each year, one bar of actions counters the change that’s been caused. The clock ticks, the bars tighten, and it cannot be paused. Around the Elephant’s graveyard, the margins grow thin until the final alarm sounds, and the endings begin.

So down the street we go with the Elephant inside, always mustering her grit as our climate action guide. And if somehow you happened to miss her, take a step back and look at the big picture.



WHALE SONG

The hall of the museum, as soon as you enter,
divides living and extinct, cut down its center.
The border between is a survival distinction.
A swell of species now faces alarming extinction.

In the middle, the skeleton of the endangered blue whale
hangs between life and death in an unfinished tale.
Pakicetus came first, millions of years before.
The first whale walked on four legs on the Tethys Sea shore.

Her hip bones remain from relatives that lived out of water,
before human contact and imminent slaughter.
Hollowed out when claimed by a two-legged owner,
to come to life she is in need of a giant organ donor.

The bones alarmingly rock from side to side,
caught up in the current of an industrial tide.
A brief second at the surface is enough to expose
from miles away, the whalers yell “Thar She Blows!

Beached at low tide along Ireland’s east coast,
Trapped in the sights of an insatiable host.
The stranding marked the eve of the whaling boom.
A crowd gathered in fascination, signalling doom.

Pressing a harpoon under her flipper to pierce;
an act amazingly petty to kill a being so fierce.
A titanic heart that could fill a drum with a beat
turned the sea red around her killer’s feet.

The Royal Fish law claimed her property of the Crown.
In layers they proceeded to fully cut her down.
Diagonal slits made in skin thick like tire rubber;
stripped off sections of gelatinous white blubber.

Boiled down into oil for lamps to keep burning,
Her materials were measured for their commercial earning.
With her layers peeled away, only the skeleton was left.
Even this was gathered up to conclude an awful theft!

Disarticulating the structure, gouging out tissue between bone,
gathering the pieces for the Natural History Museum to own.
Mixed with polymer replicas and carbon fibre joints,
strung up to iron trusses with steel cables at ten points.

Dippy the Diplodocus returns from a big tour,
attracting attention like the Crown jewel Koh-i-Noor.
Ten plaster cast copies of the original source
were commissioned by Carnegie and mounted on steel, of course!

Hope the whale replaced Dippy, who replaced George the African elephant.
A selection of mascots burdened to keep the museum relevant.
Revolted by the symbol that they were cast to become,
they no longer wished to be a token or source of income.

In a demand for climate action, the whale took a great fall.
“A crash would necessitate rebuilding it all!”
Landing on Dippy, their joints break apart,
summoning a whole new assembly to start.



Fabricated inaccurately, like the Crystal Palace Dinosaurs,
the whale is rebuilt to join her living relatives on all fours.
Like the Iguanodon that ended up with a thumb spike on its nose.
bones are stacked out of order to form her next pose.

The Great Exhibition of the Works of Industry of All Nations
financed the land purchase for the museum foundations.
Millions consuming stories of industrialized success;
the decades since proving an environmental mess.

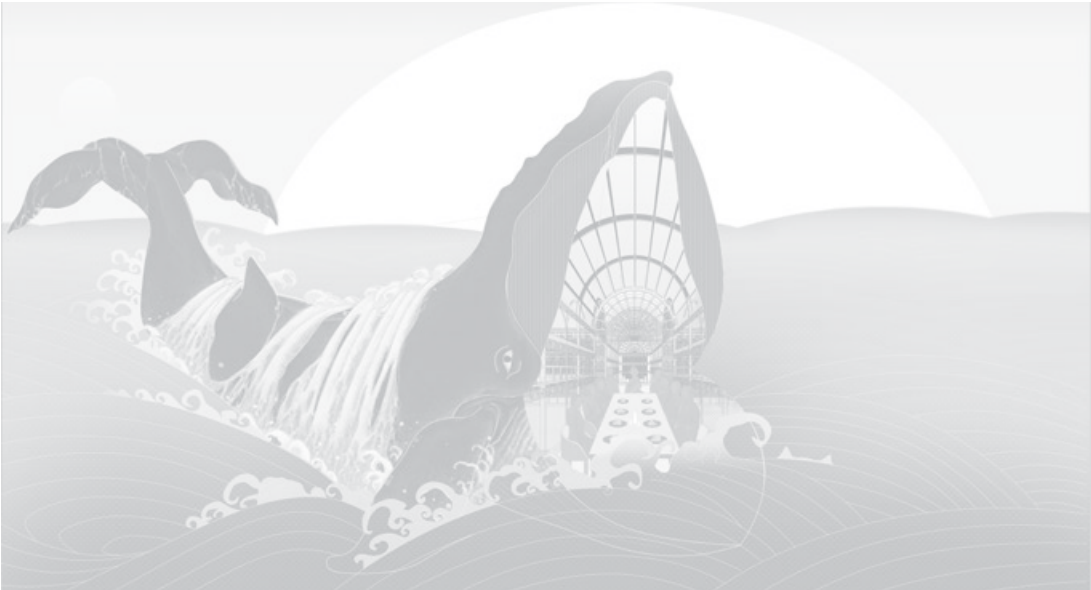
Dippy’s beam structure and pillar legs give support,
allowing the multi-species skeleton to distort.
Swallowing the Crystal Palace through her curtain-like baleen,
lifting the howdah from the African elephant—so her ears can be seen!

A table inside her mouth hosts fossil fuel benefactors,
to swallow a final meal fit for egoist extractors.
Water floods. Museum gates open. Hope whistles, pulses and breaks free.
She bursts out of Albertopolis in a climate emergency.

The whale migrates back to the sea—not without injury.
She gives the world a voice in a sonic mystery
Leading fellow whales that were stranded in the River,
the song builds with the collective call that they deliver.

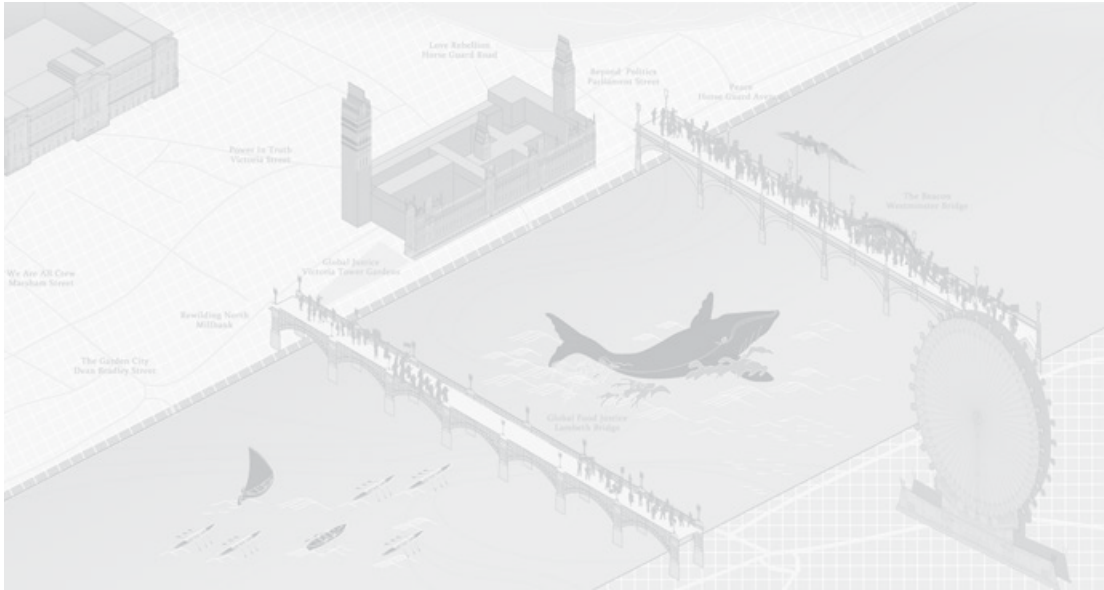
Sounds travel along with the protesting flotilla,
Amassing more attention than an aquatic Godzilla.
With a splashing of her giant flukes, the final curtain call.
Safely back above deep water she can start to fall.

With the insides of the museum, she falls to the ocean floor,
feeding hundreds of species in one life-giving pour.
Scavenging sharks break the skin to remove fleshy matter.
Smaller species move in next to collect the pieces that scatter.



Squat lobsters, hagfish, and sea stars secrete digestive juices
To break down hierarchies that the museum produces.
Sea spiders and crabs comb the sediment for remains.
Zombie worms release nutrients that the skeleton contains.

The last remnants of her bones put hope into action.
A world of sound reverberates in an endless chain reaction.
Listen to the warning whistles, it is time for a choice:
Hope rumbles—a whale of a difference you can make with your voice!



THE WAY OF THE DINOSAURS

Scene 1 In the West, paleontology and mining, two birds of a feather
Dinosaurs and fossil fuels were extracted together
The Gold Rush and Bone Wars, a race to unearth
Fossilized landscapes, exploited for their worth

Manifest destiny steamrolled west on steel rail
Staked out mineral rights and land grants, displaced the living at scale
Settlers declared ancestral land a possession free to take
Digging up matter that took Earth millions of revolutions to make

Western Expansion built a still world of specimens inside
With Andrew Carnegie as one philanthropic guide
Slabs of deep time, packed up and shipped in crates
East from the Quarry to museums across states

To stamp THE MOST COLOSSAL ANIMAL EVER ON EARTH with his name
Camp Carnegie would be Andrew's claim to fame
Diplodocus carnegii was resurrected from below
On Independence Day, beginning with one giant toe

Old bones tell of five mass extinctions so far
Of the latest, one dinosaur was cast a world star
Dippy! A symbol of the Revolutionary War
Pittsburgh: the stage for the star-spangled dinosaur

Scene 2 The terrible reptile does not stand on its own
A steel beam cast grips the curves of each bone
Fossils of bones combined with shellac, iron, and steel
Stirred up debate on what was fake and what was real

The steel-funded beast joined together some creatures
Sculpting new parts to fill in missing features
Upward from there, in vertical integration
A towering dinomania industrialist creation

Metal beam and column sections rolled out on repeat
As skyscrapers rose up and down the street
Among these the Carnegie Steel Company tower
– the headquarters for his eminent wealth and power

Dark skies, sun up to sun down, laboring without break
Workers fed the smoking machine with sweat and much ache
A single holiday they received on the 4th of July
On the day that Dippy was found, let the fireworks fly!

On a fiery effort to halt exploitation they bled
Went on strike over Independence Day at Homestead
Workers demanded plant safety and fair wage
For the open-hearth furnace to continue to rage



Scene 3 Carnegie’s Palace of Culture was an attempt to settle
Social heat bubbling at degrees of molten metal
When Carnegie Steel merged into the largest corporation
The richest man in the world turned to philanthropic donation

His *Gospel of Wealth*—a handbook for a life of excess—
Professed: inequality is essential to progress!
Libraries, parks, and museums were The Crowning of Labor
or the duty of a man of wealth to his less privileged neighbor

The House That Dippy Built was the robber baron’s view
To fit the large skeleton, the Museum further grew
Dippy was the centrepiece of the Grand Staircase
Bringing the world to workers who labour at the base

When the King asked for his own, it was surely no trouble
For the British Museum they would simply make a double
Plaster copies of Dippy were cast from a mold
And repeated for many more heads of state to behold

The Hall of Architecture that Dippy stands beside
Shaped a plaster world where old masters reside
The factory system and the industrial revolution
Reproduced uneven wealth and much mass pollution

Scene 4 A FREE TO THE PEOPLE museum came at great cost
Lands and lives damaged and many species lost
Hell with the lid taken off, carbon out in the air,
A trove of toxic harm, what a legacy to bear!

After most dinosaurs went extinct, only birds remained
Now many in turn are taxidermy mounts, very neatly framed
In a Fable for Tomorrow, was a Spring with no voices
the canary in a coal mine to caution human choices

Pipelines and Pipe Dreams: a colossal fracking mess!
Calling Natural Gas “Green Energy” puts more under stress
Drilling land in Pennsylvania for remaining carbon stores
Sends more living to museums, the way of dinosaurs

As life is held still, the Earth continues its motion
A world beyond fossil fools is the burning revolution
Birds, people, and critters, all together in mammoth size
A flock of climate action lights up the darkened skies

The Cloud Factory pumping soot out of stacks
is removed from service with tiny mighty acts
Land titles are restructured to leave fossils buried deep
Carbon’s tucked in rocky beds and settled back to sleep

